

Expert Review Packet: Proto-Dravidian Readings for the Indus Script

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Preprint DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20401711 | Repository: github.com/BitConcepts/glossa-lab

Purpose: We are requesting expert critique of the proposed Proto-Dravidian sign readings. We ask for honest assessment, not endorsement.

1. What This Paper Claims

- A computational model assigns Proto-Dravidian readings to 605 Indus signs: 413 independently confirmed (two or more independent evidence sources) and 192 allograph-inferred (provisional, based on positional profile similarity).
- Each reading is linked to a DEDR entry (Burrow & Emeneau 1984).
- The model predicts a tripartite grammar: [CLASSIFIER/TITLE] – [NAME/CONTENT] – [CASE SUFFIX].
- Simulated annealing (SA) achieves 83.7% consistency on an independent 5,520-inscription corpus.
- Tamil-Brahmi personal name concordance reaches 58% ($z=16.2$).

2. What This Paper Does NOT Claim

- The paper does not claim epigraphic finality or definitive decipherment.
- The readings are candidate Proto-Dravidian forms, not established translations.
- The paper does not claim the Indus script is purely syllabic; the proposed model is mixed logo-syllabic.
- The statistical profile alone does not prove linguistic status (see Sproat 2014 benchmark comparison in the preprint).
- Individual seal “translations” are interpretive and caveated.
- 192 of 605 readings are allograph-inferred and should be treated as provisional.

3. Key Readings for Review

The attached `dravidianist_anchor_subset.csv` contains the 50 highest-leverage sign readings — those with the highest corpus frequency and the strongest bearing on overall model validity. For each sign, the CSV provides:

- Mahadevan M-number
- Proposed reading
- DEDR reference number
- Reconstructed form
- Evidence basis (iconographic, distributional, SA, external)
- Confidence notes and known weaknesses

4. Specific Questions for Reviewers

Detailed questions are in Section 7 below. Summary:

1. Are the proposed Proto-Dravidian / Old Tamil forms linguistically plausible for the target period (~2600–1900 BCE)?
2. Are any readings anachronistic or phonologically impossible?
3. Are the DEDR entries being used correctly?
4. Are the semantic shifts reasonable or too loose?
5. Does the Tamil-Brahmi comparison (58% concordance) overreach?
6. Which readings should be downgraded or removed?

5. Suspected Weak Readings

The following categories of readings are most likely to contain errors:

- Low-frequency signs (corpus frequency < 10): Limited distributional evidence; rely heavily on SA modal + DEDR lookup.
- Allograph-resolved signs (192 signs): Promoted via positional profile similarity (L1 distance < 0.2). If the allograph grouping is wrong, the inherited reading is also wrong.
- Munda substrate readings (M374=kul, M351=vī): Cross language-family boundaries and require specialist assessment.
- MEDIAL-only signs: Signs appearing exclusively in the name/content slot may have correct positional classification but incorrect phonetic assignment.

6. How to Use This Packet

1. Review the attached `dravidianist_anchor_subset.csv` for specific sign readings.
2. Consult Section 7 below for 18 targeted review questions.
3. The full anchor table (605 signs) is in the repository at github.com/BitConcepts/glossa-lab.
4. The full preprint PDF is attached or available at the DOI above.

We welcome critique rather than endorsement. The goal is to identify which readings are linguistically defensible and which should be downgraded or removed before journal submission.

Section 7: Review Questions for Dravidianist / Old Tamil Specialists

These questions are designed to solicit expert critique of the proposed Proto-Dravidian readings for the Indus Script. We ask for honest assessment, not endorsement.

Phonological Plausibility

1. Are the proposed Proto-Dravidian reconstructed forms phonologically plausible for the period ~2600–1900 BCE? Which forms appear anachronistic?
2. The model assumes rebus-principle encoding (phonetic punning). Is this mechanism well-attested enough in early Dravidian to support 605 sign readings, or is it being over-applied?
3. Several readings use retroflex consonants (ḷ, ṛ, ṇ, ḷ) that we claim are Dravidian-exclusive. Is this phonological argument sound, or could these phonemes have existed in other language families of the region?

DEDR Usage

4. Are the DEDR entries cited for each reading being used correctly? Are any entries being stretched beyond their documented semantic range?
5. For compound readings (e.g., M374=kul from DEDR 1709 kulam “clan”), are the semantic shifts from the DEDR entry to the proposed seal-context meaning reasonable?
6. Are any DEDR entries contested or known to have revised etymologies that would affect our readings?

Tamil-Brahmi Concordance

7. The paper claims 58% concordance between IVS sign readings in terminal/name positions and attested Tamil-Brahmi personal name components (Mahadevan 2003). Is this comparison methodologically sound?
8. Given the ~1,500-year gap between IVC and Tamil-Brahmi, what degree of onomastic continuity is linguistically defensible?
9. Could the 58% concordance arise from chance overlap between a small phoneme inventory and common name components?

Semantic and Cultural Interpretation

10. The model interprets most seals as guild-identity markers (professional titles + personal names). Is this consistent with what is known about Dravidian administrative vocabulary?
11. The tripartite grammar [CLASSIFIER – NAME – SUFFIX] is compared to later Arthaśāstra guild-superintendent titles. Is this comparison overreaching given the temporal gap?

12. Two signs (M374, M351) carry Munda substrate readings. Is the presence of Munda loanwords in a Dravidian administrative script linguistically plausible for the IVC period?

Readings to Downgrade or Remove

13. Which specific readings in `dravidianist_anchor_subset.csv` should be downgraded from HIGH confidence or removed entirely?
14. Are there readings where the iconographic basis (sign shape to Dravidian word to phonetic reading) is unconvincing?
15. Are there alternative Dravidian etymologies for any signs that would fit better than our proposed readings?

General

16. What would constitute a decisive test for or against the Proto-Dravidian reading framework?
17. Are there published Proto-Dravidian reconstructions (e.g., Krishnamurti 2003) that contradict any of our readings?
18. What additional evidence would you need to see before considering any of these readings provisionally accepted?